Twenty-two-year-old Santhan was a member of the intelligence wing of the LTTE. Records earlier supplied by Colombo showed he had studied till the fifth standard in a government school in Jaffna. He had come in contact with Sivarasan in 1986 and soon earned the latter's confidence. Two years later, Sivarasan sent him to Madras for further study funded by the LTTE. Santhan took admission in the Madras Institute of Engineering and Technology.[15]

Officers of the SIT took turns to hear Santhan's story from the man himself. Sivarasan had persuaded Santhan to join him in killing Padmanabha, then considered to be the arch-rival of Prabhakaran. Santhan started following the movements of Padmanabha and kept Sivarasan posted. His groundwork eventually led to their success, with the assassination of the EPRLF leader in June 1990. He left with Sivarasan the very next day and returned to Jaffna. Prabhakaran and Pottu Amman lavished praise on him for his work in the assassination.

By the last week of April 1991, Amman had assigned Santhan to the team Sivarasan was going to lead to Tamil Nadu. It included Shubha, Dhanu, Sivaruban and Nero. Later, they all took shelter in the infamous Kodungaiyur house. Sivarasan introduced him to the rest. On the evening of 9 May, he introduced Santhan to Haribabu, Murugan and Peraribalan at the Marina beach political rally. That same night, Sivarasan took him to his Porur hideout and introduced him to Jayakumar. But his accommodation was arranged with Haribabu. Over the next seven days, Haribabu took Santhan for shopping essentials. Camaraderie developed between them instantly. Haribabu was always thrilled meeting an LTTE cadre. Reportedly, he wanted to become one of them. Santhan's statement corroborated what Haribabu's father, Sundarmani, had earlier claimed. Haribabu had to coax and cajole his mother to accommodate Santhan in their house. There was no space to accommodate a stranger, especially when there were other female members staying under the same roof.